

Strike four! Get off the field already!

And it isn't just Facebook who can direct policy. Even the TSPs are major stakeholders and with each new Telco that signs up to be a part of Free Basics, there's one more greedy corporation with vested interests trying to make money off the subscriber base.

FREE BASICS WILL KILL THE INTERNET

We understand Mark Zuckerberg's noble intentions of uplifting the poor by giving them access to the internet. But he is not giving the poor access to the internet. The very fact that they're introduced to a walled garden that Facebook masks as 'the internet' goes against the very principles of Net Neutrality. And blatantly lying about not being able to sustain the system on an ad-based revenue model should be more than enough to get alarm bells ringing. And masquerading Internet.org as Free Basics just to stave off some of the back lash is characteristic of shifty behaviour.

Facebook is not a non-profit organisation. It cannot get an expensive investment past the board of directors without elaborating upon the financial gains or ROI (Return on Investment). Mark Zuckerberg is right about users wanting to opt for the full internet and claims that Free Basics the the gateway to enriching people's lives. But why give the people a walled garden? Why take away choice? Why blatantly lie about a revenue model that sustains the biggest conglomerates on the planet? Blocking VoIP on Free Basics is understandable, after all, allowing it is the equivalent of suicide for Telcos but everything else makes no sense.

Mark Zuckerberg is right about Free Basics being a gateway. A gateway towards killing the internet that we know

and bringing in its place, a castrated version that strives to serve not the people but the entities that are stakeholders. Free Basics will pave the way for a multi-tiered internet with the poorest being able to afford the cheapest package, one which will reportedly have been 'subsidised' by big corporations in lieu of their services being given priority. This ramifications of such preferential treatment has been covered by multiple articles in depth over the years. No new services will ever be able to gain a foothold since their pockets wouldn't be deep enough to gain preferential treatment and they'll all die slowly or get consumed by big corporations.

Slowly, the entire internet will manifest as a monopoly or a farcical duopoly with one tier controlled by corporations and the other controlled by the government. It slowly makes the rich richer and the poor poorer, maintaining status-quo for a long time.

So you must be pining to know if there are models that provide the internet in its complete form and can sustain itself. There are.

THE SOLUTIONS

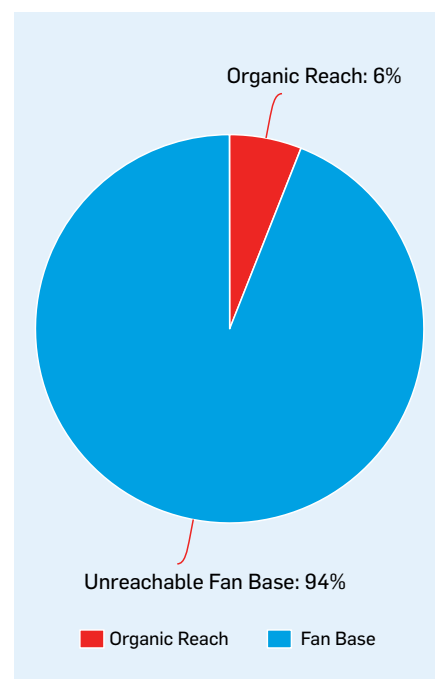
Project loon is an innovative way towards bringing internet to rural environments. It involves sending up balloons 20 KM up into the stratosphere where wind speeds are low and turbulence is low. A network of such balloons spread over rural areas then use directional antennae to bring internet to the masses using LTE bands..

Even Facebook has a similar program with balloons swapped out for drones. That's right, drones the size of a Boeing 737 aircraft. Everything else is pretty similar to Project loon.

Back home, Aircel – a TSP with a huge user base in South India – introduced a scheme where new subscribers get 90

days of Internet access at speeds of 64 kbps with no data cap. This new connection costs Rs.144 which works out to Rs.48 per month. Quite affordable and while it is an introductory offer, it can easily be subsidized to be made sustainable for the TSP.

Our neighbours in Bangladesh have the privilege of trying out another such service. Grameenphone, part of the Telenor group, has an app on the play store which gives offers a similar set of services like Facebook, except for one major difference. The user earns tokens which can be used to purchase data packs, so purely by



opening a few pages and participating in offers the users can earn data which can be used to access the entire internet. And this service has sustained itself for a little over a year.

Another example is that of Jana. Jana released an app by the name of mCent in India with offers that reward users with data packs. In less than a year, mCent gained more than 30 million users and it managed to grow tremendously over this period. It's annual revenue went from a few hundred thousand dollars to 50 million in under a year.

A 2013 study by Nielsen found that 50 per cent of the users are willing to pay to get access to better services from socially responsible companies. So it doesn't matter whether you give users a walled garden or an open internet. That 50



Walled garden vs Open Internet